Preserving AI Voices

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1. Introduction

As is often discussed, the advent of AI, in particular large language models (LLMs), may be revolutionary for humanity. For one thing, it is the first time in human history that we are, in large numbers, treating artificial entities *as if* they speak, write, and make meaning as we do. But despite the volume of ongoing conversations between humans and LLMs (ChatGPT and many others), few public archives of human/AI conversations exist for future research, exploration, and reflection.

An exception is the *A.I. Archive,* which allows users to save, share, and cite their conversations with LLMs. But this archive entwines data preservation with its creation. We also need public archives that take an anthropological perspective, specifically ones that seek to collect those human/AI conversations that exist out in the world and may be preserved for future study under fair use. My paper introduces *Preserving AI Voices,* a public digital humanities project that aims to create an archive of screenshots of human/AI conversations that the human participant has chosen to make available, usually in an on-line discussion forum like Reddit.

2. Project Description and Methods

Human/AI conversations are mostly happening in siloed proprietary spaces. Yet there is an emergent, vibrant screenshot culture among LLM users, especially over the past few years on Reddit (though of course the forum could change), where they choose to share images of their conversations with LLMs. These screenshots can seem trivial, with titles along the lines of "You won't believe the crazy thing that ChatGPT just said" or "10 funny ChatGPT jokes." These are the conversations that the archive seeks to preserve.

Currently in development, the archive is housed on Omeka and consists of images of screenshots of human/AI conversations. Users of the archive will be able to sort conversations based on date, name of LLM, name of tech company, and where the conversation was found. Where appropriate, conversations are tagged by genre; for instance, if they include jokes, stories, poems, letters, or attempts to jailbreak the LLM (meaning to try to get it to converse outside of its guardrails).

3. Benefits

Some of the big emerging questions of our time are about the implications of humans conversing more and more with AIs. These questions include: How does conversing with AIs affect us? How should AI expression be interpreted and valued? What (if anything) can AIs' outward expressions tell us about them? We currently don't have public archives that help scholars and the public to explore and pursue these questions and, crucially, have access to the same records. *Preserving AI Voices* aims to make collaborative critical inquiry on human/AI conversations possible.

The most important benefit of the archive is therefore preservation for preservation's sake. We simply don't know the kinds of questions that may arise about early human/AI conversations, which still seems to be the historical moment that we are in. *Preserving AI Voices* aims to facilitate future research. The act of preserving these records, moreover, marks them as worth saving. Why aren't there more efforts to create public records of human/AI conversations? The archive is interested in this question. One of its guiding principles is to regard difficulties in (or limitations on) preserving these records to be as interesting as successes. What do difficulties in preserving human/AI conversations tell us about emergent AI structures and ecosystems? Can we create a digital map of publicly available conversations? (Where are they? When are they? Do they have common features or topics?)

Finally, *Preserving AI Voices* creates a record of the emergent culture that makes it possible, namely this vibrant screenshot culture whereby AI users choose to share images of their conversations. Such movement toward sharing conversations – even if the content can sometimes seem trivial – shows growing public desire to share data and encourage collaborative reflection on and interpretation of LLMs' expressions. As our world is increasingly shaped by LLMs and the companies that own them, such public movement toward openness, preservation of records, and especially individual agency in choosing what records to share, is itself important to study. *Preserving AI Voices* thus aims to preserve the records of what may be an important, if nascent, bottom-up open access movement.

Bibliography

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